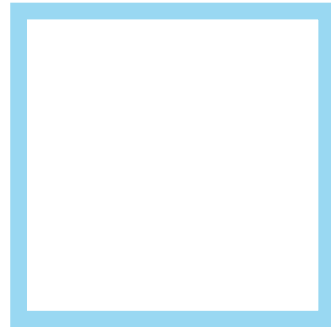


HEALTH AND CARE WORKER VISA



LOCATION: [HOME](#) » [WORK & BUSINESS IMMIGRATION](#) » [LONG TERM WORK VISAS](#) » [UK HEALTH AND CARE WORKER VISA](#)

UK Health and Care Worker Visa: Skilled Worker Route for Sponsored Health & Care Jobs

PUBLISHED: 30TH OCTOBER 2025

In This Guide

1. Benefits of the Health and Care Worker Visa
2. Requirements for a Health and Care Worker Visa
3. Health and Care Worker Visa Eligible Jobs
4. Professional Registration for the Health and Care Worker Visa
5. Approved UK Employers for the Health and Care Worker Visa
6. Certificate of Sponsorship (CoS) Requirement for the Health and Care Worker Visa
7. Health and Care Worker Visa Salary Requirement
8. Introduction of the Temporary Shortage List and Changes to the Immigration Salary List
9. New Entrants to the Labour Market Under the Health and Care Worker Visa Route
10. English Language Requirement for the Health and Care Worker Visa
11. Immigration Skills Charge for the Health and Care Worker Visa

- [12. Financial Maintenance Requirement for the Health and Care Worker Visa](#)
- [13. Criminal Record Certificate Requirement for the Health and Care Worker Visa](#)
- [14. Suitability and Good Character Requirements for the Health and Care Worker Visa](#)
- [15. Application Fees and Fee Reductions for the Health and Care Worker Visa](#)
- [16. Exemption from the Immigration Health Surcharge for Health and Care Workers](#)
- [17. Cooling-Off Period Rules for the Health and Care Worker Visa](#)
- [18. Fast-Track Processing Times for the Health and Care Worker Visa](#)
- [19. Duration of Stay on a Health and Care Worker Visa](#)
- [20. Maximum Length of Stay on the Health and Care Worker Visa](#)
- [21. Dependants of Health and Care Worker Visa Holders](#)
- [22. Switching to the Health and Care Worker Visa from Another UK Visa](#)
- [23. Compliance and Conditions of Stay on the Health and Care Worker Visa](#)
- [24. Settlement \(ILR\) as a Health and Care Worker in the UK](#)
- [25. Career Opportunities After Settlement on the Health and Care Worker Visa](#)
- [26. Pathway to British Citizenship After Health and Care Worker Visa Settlement](#)
- [27. UK Health and Care Worker Visa FAQs](#)
- [28. How Our Immigration Barristers Can Help](#)
- [29. Contact Richmond Chambers Immigration Barristers](#)

The Health and Care Worker Visa is a sub-category of the [Skilled Worker route](#), designed for qualified doctors, nurses, allied health professionals, and individuals working in the adult social care sector who have been offered an eligible health or social care job in the UK.

The Health and Care Worker Visa provides a pathway to settlement, with applicants eligible to apply for indefinite leave to remain after five years of

continuous residence.

Most Health and Care Worker Visa applicants can be accompanied or joined by a dependent partner and children. However, dependents of care workers and senior care workers (occupation codes 6145 and 6146) are no longer permitted to come to or stay in the UK.

1. Benefits of the Health and Care Worker Visa

Applicants for the Health and Care Worker Visa enjoy several advantages compared to applicants under the general Skilled Worker route. These include:

- **Reduced Visa Application Fees:** Health and Care Worker Visa applicants pay a significantly reduced application fee. This reduction also applies to their dependent partners and children applying under the route.
- **Priority Processing:** UK Visas and Immigration aims to prioritise Health and Care Worker Visa applications, with most decisions issued within three weeks of the applicant providing their biometric information.
- **Exemption from the Immigration Health Surcharge (IHS):** Health and Care Worker Visa applicants, along with their dependent partner and children, are exempt from paying the IHS, allowing access to NHS services without additional cost.

2. Requirements for a Health and Care Worker Visa

In order to qualify for a Health and Care Worker Visa, you will need to satisfy UK Visas and Immigration that:

- You are aged 18 or over;
- You are a qualified doctor, nurse, allied health professional or person working in the adult social care sector;
- You have a job offer for an eligible role listed in the relevant Standard Occupational Classification (SOC 2020) codes for the Health and Care Worker route;
- You will be employed or engaged by a UK health or care sector employer that is approved by the Home Office as a licensed sponsor;
- You have a valid **Certificate of Sponsorship** from your employer for the role you intend to undertake;
- You will be paid a salary that meets or exceeds both the general salary threshold and the going rate for the SOC code, subject to permitted reductions (e.g. new entrants, ISL roles, PhD qualifications);

- You meet the English language requirement to at least CEFR level B1 in all four components (reading, writing, speaking and listening);
- Your sponsor has paid any applicable [Immigration Skills Charge](#) (note: NHS bodies are generally exempt);
- You have sufficient funds to support yourself in the UK, unless exempt from the financial requirement;
- You have provided a criminal record certificate, if required for your occupation;
- You have provided a valid tuberculosis (TB) certificate, if required due to your country of residence.

To discuss your Health and Care Worker Visa application with one of our immigration barristers, contact our Health and Care Worker Route lawyers on 0203 617 9173 or complete our enquiry form below.

3. Health and Care Worker Visa Eligible Jobs

To qualify for a Health and Care Worker Visa, you must have a job offer in an eligible health or social care role, as defined by specific [Standard Occupational Classification](#) (SOC) 2020 codes listed in Appendix Skilled Occupations.

The current list of eligible SOC codes includes:

- 1171 – Health services and public health managers and directors
- 1232 – Residential, day and domiciliary care managers and proprietors
- 2113 – Biochemists and biomedical scientists
- 2114 – Physical scientists
- 2211 – Generalist medical practitioners
- 2212 – Specialist medical practitioners
- 2221 – Physiotherapists
- 2222 – Occupational therapists
- 2223 – Speech and language therapists
- 2224 – Psychotherapists and cognitive behaviour therapists
- 2225 – Clinical psychologists
- 2226 – Other psychologists

- 2229 – Therapy professionals not elsewhere classified
- 2231 – Midwifery nurses
- 2232 – Registered community nurses
- 2233 – Registered specialist nurses
- 2234 – Registered nurse practitioners
- 2235 – Registered mental health nurses
- 2236 – Registered children's nurses
- 2237 – Other registered nursing professionals
- 2251 – Pharmacists
- 2252 – Optometrists
- 2253 – Dental practitioners
- 2254 – Medical radiographers
- 2255 – Paramedics
- 2256 – Podiatrists
- 2259 – Other health professionals not elsewhere classified
- 2461 – Social workers
- 3111 – Laboratory technicians
- 3211 – Dispensing opticians
- 3212 – Pharmaceutical technicians
- 6131 – Nursing auxiliaries and assistants

For in-country applicants on the SOC 2020 occupation code '6135' and '6136', they must have already been working legally in their job with their sponsor for at least the 3 months ending on the date the CoS was assigned to the applicant.

This is an exhaustive list of eligible occupations under the Health and Care Worker Visa route. To qualify, your job must appear on this list, and your sponsor must assign your Certificate of Sponsorship under one of these SOC codes. Certain other healthcare-related roles not listed here may still qualify under the general [Skilled Worker visa](#) route, but will not benefit from the Health and Care Worker-specific advantages (such as exemption from the Immigration Health Surcharge or reduced visa fees).

4. Professional Registration for the Health and Care Worker Visa



For many health and care occupations, securing a job offer and obtaining a Health and Care Worker Visa is contingent on holding the appropriate professional registration or licence to practise in the UK. For example:

- Nurses and midwives must be registered with the [Nursing and Midwifery Council \(NMC\)](#);
- Doctors must be registered with the [General Medical Council \(GMC\)](#);
- Allied health professionals-such as physiotherapists, radiographers, and paramedics-typically require registration with the [Health and Care Professions Council \(HCPC\)](#);
- Pharmacists must be registered with the [General Pharmaceutical Council \(GPhC\)](#);
- Dentists must be registered with the [General Dental Council \(GDC\)](#).

Where professional registration is required by UK law for the role, sponsors must confirm that the applicant holds (or will hold) such registration before assigning a Certificate of Sponsorship. In many cases, evidence of registration must also be submitted with the visa application.

Applicants should ensure that they begin the professional registration process as early as possible, as delays in obtaining registration can lead to delays in sponsorship, refusal of a visa application, or the withdrawal of a job offer.

5. Approved UK Employers for the Health and Care Worker Visa

To qualify for a Health and Care Worker Visa, you must be employed or engaged by a UK health or social care sector employer that is approved by the Home Office as a licensed sponsor under the Skilled Worker route.

A wide range of organisations are eligible to hold a sponsor licence for the Health and Care Worker route, including:

- NHS bodies, including NHS Trusts and NHS Foundation Trusts across England, Wales, Scotland and Northern Ireland;
- Providers of regulated activities under the Health and Social Care Act 2008, registered with the Care Quality Commission (CQC) in England;
- Care providers in Scotland, registered with Social Care and Social Work Improvement Scotland (Care Inspectorate);
- Care providers in Wales, regulated under the Regulation and Inspection of Social Care (Wales) Act 2016;

- Care providers in Northern Ireland, registered with or regulated by the Regulation and Quality Improvement Authority (RQIA);
- GP Federations and organisations delivering primary care services under NHS contracts;
- Medical and dental service providers contracted to supply services to the NHS;
- Regulatory bodies (e.g. the General Medical Council, General Dental Council, General Chiropractic Council), where applicable.

Important Changes to Sponsorship of Care Workers under the Skilled Worker Route

Since 22 July 2025, employers are no longer able to sponsor new applicants for the role of care worker under the Skilled Worker visa route, as this occupation has been removed from the list of eligible roles.

However, care workers who are already on the Skilled Worker route before this date will be permitted to remain on the route and extend their stay, up until the route is fully closed in 2028.

If you are not sure whether your employer is an approved employer for the purpose of the Health and Care Worker Visa route, our immigration barristers can advise you further.

6. Certificate of Sponsorship (CoS) Requirement for the Health and Care Worker Visa

To apply for a Health and Care Worker Visa, you must have a valid **Certificate of Sponsorship (CoS)** for the role you intend to undertake. This is an electronic document generated through the Home Office's Sponsorship Management System (SMS) and is not a physical certificate.

Your Certificate of Sponsorship must be issued by a **licensed sponsor** -an organisation that is authorised by the Home Office to sponsor workers under the Skilled Worker route and, where applicable, the Health and Care Worker sub-route. Eligible sponsors include the NHS, organisations delivering services to the **NHS**, and adult social care providers, among others.

If an organisation is not currently approved as a licensed sponsor, it must first apply for and be granted a **Sponsor Licence** before it can issue a Certificate of Sponsorship.

The Certificate of Sponsorship must include:

- Your full name, job title, and proposed salary;
- The [SOC 2020 occupation code](#) corresponding to the role;
- A start date that is no more than three months after the date of your visa application;
- Confirmation that the CoS has not been withdrawn by your sponsor;
- A statement confirming how the role and applicant meet the eligibility requirements for the Health and Care Worker Visa route.

Where the sponsoring employer provides services commissioned by the NHS (but is not itself an NHS body), the Home Office may request evidence of contractual arrangements with the NHS to verify eligibility for the Health and Care Worker route.

Your Certificate of Sponsorship must have been assigned no more than three months before the date of your visa application. Using an expired CoS will result in the application being refused.

7. Health and Care Worker Visa Salary Requirement

To qualify for a Health and Care Worker Visa, you must be paid a salary that meets or exceeds both:

1. The general salary threshold, and
2. The 'going rate' for the job, based on the relevant SOC 2020 occupation code, as set out in Appendix Skilled Occupations.

National Pay Scale Occupations

For certain health and care occupations that are subject to national NHS pay scales, the minimum salary requirement is:

- £25,000 per year, or
- The going rate listed in Table 3 of [Appendix Skilled Occupations](#) for the relevant SOC 2020 code, whichever is higher.

These national pay scale occupations include:

- 2211 – Generalist medical practitioners
- 2212 – Specialist medical practitioners
- 2221–2226, 2229 – Therapy professionals

- 2231–2237 – Registered nurses and midwives
- 2251–2256, 2259 – Pharmacists and allied health professionals
- 2461 – Social workers
- 3213, 3219 – Health associate professionals
- 6131–6133 – Nursing auxiliaries, ambulance staff (excluding paramedics), and dental nurses

Occupations Based on ASHE Salary Data

For other health and care jobs where salary thresholds are based on the Annual Survey of Hours and Earnings (ASHE), the general salary threshold is £29,000 per year, unless a reduction applies under the points-based system.

These occupations include:

- 1171 – Health services and public health managers and directors
- 1231 – Health care practice managers
- 1232 – Residential, day and domiciliary care managers and proprietors
- 2113 – Biochemists and biomedical scientists
- 2114 – Physical scientists
- 3111 – Laboratory technicians
- 3211 – Dispensing opticians
- 3212 – Pharmaceutical technicians
- 6135 – Care workers and home carers
- 6136 – Senior care workers

For these roles, the required salary must equal or exceed:

- The general salary threshold (£29,000, £26,100, or £23,200 depending on tradable characteristics); and
- The going rate or a permitted percentage of it based on the applicant's profile.

Tradable Points and Salary Reductions

Applicants for ASHE-based jobs may benefit from tradable points that reduce the salary threshold if they meet certain criteria:

- An applicant with a PhD qualification which is relevant to the job may be paid a salary which equals or exceeds both £28,200 per year and 90% of the going

rate for the SOC 2020 occupation code;

- An applicant with a PhD qualification in a STEM subject which is relevant to the job may be paid a salary which equals or exceeds both £25,000 per year and 80% of the going rate for the SOC 2020 occupation code;
- An applicant with a job offer for a job on the [Immigration Salary List](#) may be paid a salary which equals or exceeds both £25,000 per year and the going rate for the SOC 2020 occupation code;
- An applicant who is a new entrant to the labour market at the start of their career may be paid a salary which equals or exceeds both £25,000 per year and 70% of the going rate for the SOC 2020 occupation code.

A “new entrant” includes applicants:

- Under 26 on the date of application;
- Switching from the Student or Graduate route;
- Working towards a UK professional registration or chartered status; or
- Sponsored for certain postdoctoral positions (Provided total time in the Skilled Worker/Graduate/Tier 2 route will not exceed 4 years.)

8. Introduction of the Temporary Shortage List and Changes to the Immigration Salary List

The [Temporary Shortage List](#) was introduced to include occupations at RQF Levels 3-5. It is time-limited. This list is different from the [Immigration Salary List](#). Being on the Temporary Shortage List means that an entry clearance application can be made where the occupation is medium skilled to RQF Level 3-5.

The Immigration Salary List (‘ISL’) has been updated and a number of occupation codes have removal dates, for example SOC codes ‘6135 Care workers and home carers’ and ‘6136 Senior care workers’ have a removal date of 22 July 2028.

To be awarded points for a job no longer on the ISL, your last permission must be for a job on the ISL and you must be applying to continue working in the same job for the same sponsor.

9. New Entrants to the Labour Market Under the Health and Care Worker Visa Route

A “new entrant” to the labour market may benefit from reduced salary thresholds under the points-based system. You may qualify as a new entrant if, at the date of

application, one of the following applies:

- You are under the age of 26;
- You are switching from the **Student** or **Graduate** route;
- You are being sponsored for a postdoctoral research position;
- You are working towards a recognised UK qualification, full registration or chartered status with the relevant professional body.

If you qualify as a new entrant, you may be paid a salary that equals or exceeds:

- £25,000 per year, and
- 70% of the going rate for the applicable SOC 2020 occupation code.

You will not qualify as a new entrant if granting your application would result in your total time with permission under the Skilled Worker, Tier 2 (General), or Graduate route exceeding four years.

10. English Language Requirement for the Health and Care Worker Visa

To qualify for a Health and Care Worker Visa, you must demonstrate your English language ability to at least level B1 (intermediate) on the Common European Framework of Reference for Languages (CEFR) in all four components: reading, writing, speaking, and listening.

You can meet the English language requirement in one of the following ways:

- You are a national of a majority English-speaking country, as defined in Appendix English Language;
- You have passed a Secure English Language Test (SELT) at CEFR level B1 or higher, with an approved provider;
- You have been awarded a degree-level academic qualification that was taught in English (you may need to provide confirmation from Ecctis, formerly UK NARIC, if the degree was obtained outside the UK);
- You obtained one of the following UK school qualifications in English while under the age of 18 and attending school in the UK:
 - GCSE or A Level in English;
 - Scottish National Qualification at level 4 or 5 in English;
 - Scottish Higher or Advanced Higher in English;

- You have previously met the English language requirement at level B1 or higher in a prior successful visa application to the Home Office.

Doctors, dentists, nurses, and midwives do not need to prove their English language ability separately if they have already passed an English language assessment accepted by their relevant professional regulatory body, such as the GMC, GDC, or NMC. In such cases, the Home Office accepts that the language requirement has been met.

11. Immigration Skills Charge for the Health and Care Worker Visa

Employers sponsoring Health and Care Worker Visa applicants are normally required to pay the **Immigration Skills Charge (ISC)** in full at the time of assigning a Certificate of Sponsorship (CoS). This charge is levied for each sponsored worker and applies each time a CoS is assigned, including for visa extensions.

The ISC is payable by the sponsor only and cannot be passed on to the applicant in any form.

Sponsors should ensure they understand whether the ISC applies to them before assigning a CoS, as failure to pay the correct charge (where applicable) can lead to visa refusals or compliance issues.

12. Financial Maintenance Requirement for the Health and Care Worker Visa

Unless exempt, Health and Care Worker Visa applicants must demonstrate that they have sufficient funds to support themselves upon arrival in the UK.

Specifically, you must show that you have at least £1,270 in available funds, held for a consecutive 28-day period, ending no more than 31 days before the date of your visa application.

You will be exempt from this financial requirement if any of the following apply:

- You are applying from within the UK and have held valid permission for 12 months or more at the time of your application; or
- Your employer certifies on your Certificate of Sponsorship that they will maintain and accommodate you during your first month in the UK, up to a minimum of £1,270, if required.

To rely on this sponsor certification, your employer must complete the 'Sponsor certifies maintenance' section of the CoS. If the financial requirement applies and

the necessary evidence is not provided, the application may be refused.

13. Criminal Record Certificate Requirement for the Health and Care Worker Visa

If you are applying for a Health and Care Worker Visa from outside the UK, you will generally be required to provide a criminal record certificate. This certificate must be issued by the relevant authority in any country where you have been present for 12 months or more (whether continuously or cumulatively) in the 10 years prior to your application, and during which you were aged 18 or over.

However, this requirement does **not** apply if you are being sponsored for a role under one of the following occupation codes:

- **2113** – Biochemists and biomedical scientists
- **2114** – Physical scientists
- **3111** – Laboratory technicians

Applicants for all other eligible health and care roles under the Skilled Worker route must meet this requirement. Where a certificate is required but not provided, the application may be refused. Applicants should therefore allow sufficient time to obtain certificates from all relevant jurisdictions before submitting their visa application.

14. Suitability and Good Character Requirements for the Health and Care Worker Visa

In addition to meeting the eligibility criteria, applicants for a Health and Care Worker Visa must satisfy suitability requirements. The Home Office will consider whether an applicant has a criminal history, previous breaches of immigration laws, false representations or outstanding debts to the NHS or Home Office. Applications may be refused where there are concerns about character, conduct or associations. Health and Care Workers are therefore advised to declare all relevant matters and seek advice if there are any potential issues that could affect the suitability assessment.

15. Application Fees and Fee Reductions for the Health and Care Worker Visa

Applicants for the Health and Care Worker Visa benefit from reduced visa application fees, provided their employer confirms on the Certificate of Sponsorship (CoS) that the role qualifies under the Health and Care Worker route.

The reduced fees also apply to dependent partners and children applying under the same route.

The fee reduction is automatically applied during the online application process, based on the information provided in the CoS.

As of April 2025, the visa application fees for Health and Care Worker applicants are:

- £304 for a Certificate of Sponsorship valid for 3 years or less;
- £590 for a Certificate of Sponsorship valid for more than 3 years.

These fees apply equally to applications made outside the UK (entry clearance) and within the UK (leave to remain or switching categories).

To benefit from the reduced fee, the CoS must clearly confirm that the job meets the eligibility criteria for the Health and Care Worker route, as specified in the sponsor management system.

16. Exemption from the Immigration Health Surcharge for Health and Care Workers

Applicants for a Health and Care Worker Visa, along with their dependent partners and children, are exempt from paying the Immigration Health Surcharge (IHS). This exemption applies where the Certificate of Sponsorship confirms eligibility under the Health and Care Worker route and the applicant is applying for entry clearance or leave to remain under this category.

17. Cooling-Off Period Rules for the Health and Care Worker Visa

Under the previous Tier 2 (General) visa route, applicants were generally subject to a 12-month 'cooling-off period', which prevented them from applying for a new Tier 2 visa if they had held Tier 2 leave within the preceding 12 months.

This restriction has been abolished under the Skilled Worker route, which includes the Health and Care Worker Visa. There is no cooling-off period, and there are no restrictions on how soon a person can apply for a Skilled Worker or Health and Care Worker Visa after holding previous permission under the Skilled Worker or other immigration routes.

Applicants are free to apply for entry clearance or switch into the Health and Care Worker route at any time, provided they meet the relevant requirements.

18. Fast-Track Processing Times for the Health and Care Worker Visa

According to Home Office guidance, Health and Care Worker Visa applications are prioritised by UK Visas and Immigration (UKVI), with the aim that the majority of applications are processed within three weeks of the date the applicant attends their biometric appointment.

However, actual processing times may vary depending on factors such as local availability of biometric appointments, the accuracy and completeness of the application, and seasonal demand.

19. Duration of Stay on a Health and Care Worker Visa

If your application for a Health and Care Worker Visa is approved, you will be granted entry clearance or permission to stay for a period that ends 14 days after the end date of your Certificate of Sponsorship (CoS). The maximum duration of the visa granted is five years, based on the employment period stated on your CoS.

The Certificate of Sponsorship will specify the start and end date of your role, which determines the length of leave granted. The additional 14 days are included to allow time for departure or to apply for further leave.

You can usually apply to extend your Health and Care Worker Visa if you continue to meet the relevant requirements, including the salary threshold, and if:

- You are continuing in the same job as when you were last granted permission; or
- Your job remains within the same SOC 2020 occupation code; or
- You are still working for the same sponsor who assigned your current CoS.

If any of these conditions change, for example, if you switch to a different occupation code or change employers, you will need to apply for a new visa, not an extension.

20. Maximum Length of Stay on the Health and Care Worker Visa

Under the former Tier 2 (General) route, applicants were generally subject to a maximum stay of six years, after which they were required to leave the UK or switch into another route.

This restriction has been abolished under the Skilled Worker route, including the Health and Care Worker sub-category. There is now no maximum time limit on how long a person can remain in the UK under the Health and Care Worker Visa, provided they continue to meet the relevant requirements.

Applicants may be granted up to five years' leave at a time, and they may extend their visa or reapply as needed, without a cumulative time cap. Continuous lawful residence under this route can also lead to settlement (Indefinite Leave to Remain) after five years.

21. Dependants of Health and Care Worker Visa Holders

Health and Care Workers may be joined or accompanied by a dependent partner aged 18 or over and/or a dependent child under the age of 18. Dependent partners are permitted to work and study in the UK without restriction, while dependent children may attend state-funded education. Dependants may also access healthcare via the NHS and, if eligible, may apply for settlement after completing the required residence period.

Since 11 March 2024, care workers and senior care workers (occupation codes 6145 and 6146) are no longer permitted to bring dependents to the UK.

However, care workers and senior care workers who were granted a Health and Care Worker Visa before this date may continue to be accompanied or joined by dependents, including if they switch employers to another sponsor that meets Care Quality Commission (CQC) regulatory requirements. On 22 July 2025, the role of care workers and senior care workers were removed from the Skilled Worker route.

Dependent family members may also later switch into their own immigration routes, such as a Skilled Worker Visa, without leaving the UK. The Health and Care Worker Visa fee reduction and exemption from the Immigration Health Surcharge also apply to dependent partners and children.

22. Switching to the Health and Care Worker Visa from Another UK Visa

Applicants who currently hold leave to remain in the UK under another immigration category may be eligible to switch into the Health and Care Worker Visa route. However, switching is not permitted if the applicant currently has, or was last granted, permission as a Visitor, Short-term Student, Parent of a Child Student, Seasonal Worker, Domestic Worker in a Private Household, or as a person with leave granted outside the Immigration Rules.

Those currently holding, or who last held, permission as a Student may only switch into the Health and Care Worker route if they have completed the course of study for which their Confirmation of Acceptance for Studies (CAS) was assigned; or if the course ended before the start date of the role on the Certificate of Sponsorship (CoS); or, in the case of PhD candidates, if they have completed at least 24 months of their doctoral studies.

International students who have completed a UK degree in a health or social care-related field such as nursing, physiotherapy, social work, or medicine may be well placed to switch into the route, provided they have a job offer from a licensed sponsor for a role that falls within an eligible Standard Occupational Classification (SOC 2020) code. This also applies to individuals holding a Graduate visa, subject to their ability to meet all other route requirements.

All applicants must have a valid CoS issued by an approved sponsor and must meet the relevant salary and English language requirements. It is essential to ensure that the job offered meets the sponsorship criteria under the Health and Care Worker Visa route before submitting an application to switch.

23. Compliance and Conditions of Stay on the Health and Care Worker Visa

General Compliance Obligations

Holders of the Health and Care Worker Visa must comply with a number of conditions attached to their permission to stay in the UK. These include working for the employer named on their Certificate of Sponsorship (CoS), performing the specific job for which they were sponsored, and remaining within the same Standard Occupational Classification (SOC) code. They must not access public funds and must notify the Home Office of significant changes in their circumstances, including a change of residential address.

Maintaining Sponsorship

A valid sponsor is essential to lawful residence under this route. If a visa holder's employment ends or their sponsor withdraws their sponsorship, they must act promptly by securing a new job with a licensed sponsor and applying for a new visa before beginning the new role. Failure to do so may result in curtailment of their permission to stay and could negatively affect future immigration applications.

Supplementary and Secondary Employment

Health and Care Worker Visa holders are permitted to undertake supplementary employment, provided it does not exceed 20 hours per week, is in an occupation listed in Tables 1, 2 or 3 of Appendix Skilled Occupations and is outside the working hours covered by the CoS. They must continue working in their sponsored role while undertaking any supplementary work.

If a visa holder wishes to take on additional employment that does not meet these conditions, they must first apply to UK Visas and Immigration to update their permission before starting the new role.

Impact of Changing Employer or Role

Health and Care Worker Visa holders may change employers or roles during their period of leave, but must apply to update their visa before doing so. A new Certificate of Sponsorship must be obtained from an approved sponsor, and permission must be granted before the new employment begins.

If a visa holder is promoted within the same organisation and the new role remains within the same SOC code, a new visa application is generally not required. However, if the promotion results in a change to a different SOC code, a fresh application must be submitted. It is essential to ensure that lawful status is maintained and that employment remains authorised at all times.

24. Settlement (ILR) as a Health and Care Worker in the UK

Health and Care Worker Visa holders may apply for Indefinite Leave to Remain (ILR), also referred to as settlement, after completing a continuous period of five years in the UK. In order to qualify for settlement, applicants must demonstrate to UK Visas and Immigration (UKVI) that:

- They have spent a continuous period of five years in the UK with valid permission, either entirely on the Health and Care Worker route or in combination with time spent on other qualifying routes, including: Skilled Worker, Global Talent, Innovator Founder, Tier 2 Minister of Religion, International Sportsperson, Representative of an Overseas Business, Tier 1 (excluding Graduate Entrepreneur), or Scale-up;
- They have not been absent from the UK for more than 180 days in any 12-month period during the five-year qualifying period, in accordance with the continuous residence requirement;
- They have passed the [Life in the UK test](#), unless aged 65 or over;

- Their sponsoring employer is still approved by the Home Office and continues to require them to work in the same role for the foreseeable future;
- They are being, and will continue to be, paid a salary that meets or exceeds the applicable ILR salary threshold.

The standard salary requirement for settlement is £31,300 per year or the going rate for the relevant SOC 2020 occupation code, whichever is higher. However, a lower salary threshold may apply in certain circumstances under the transitional provisions for Skilled Worker and Tier 2 (General) migrants who were sponsored before specific rule changes came into effect on 4 April 2024.

Applicants should ensure that they meet all settlement criteria before applying, particularly in relation to salary, continuous residence, and employer sponsorship.

25. Career Opportunities After Settlement on the Health and Care Worker Visa

Once Health and Care Workers obtain Indefinite Leave to Remain (ILR), they are no longer subject to immigration restrictions or sponsorship requirements. This immigration status provides the flexibility to pursue a wider range of career opportunities across the health and social care sectors.

With settlement, individuals are free to move between employers, take up senior or specialist roles within the NHS, private healthcare providers, or social care organisations, and undertake agency or locum work without restriction. Many also choose to invest in their professional development by pursuing further study, undertaking additional qualifications, or establishing independent healthcare or care-related businesses.

In addition to offering greater career mobility, settlement provides a pathway to British citizenship, subject to meeting the relevant residence and good character requirements. Over time, ILR holders may become eligible for leadership, management, or advisory roles within public health bodies, regulatory agencies, and the wider care sector.

26. Pathway to British Citizenship After Health and Care Worker Visa Settlement

Health and Care Workers who have obtained Indefinite Leave to Remain (ILR) may be eligible to apply for British citizenship by naturalisation, subject to meeting the relevant legal requirements. In most cases, applicants must have held ILR for at least 12 months before applying. However, those who are married to or

in a civil partnership with a British citizen may be eligible to apply immediately upon being granted ILR, without the 12-month waiting period.

In addition to the residence requirement, applicants must also satisfy the good character requirement, meet the English language requirement, and successfully complete the Life in the UK Test. Health and Care Workers intending to make the UK their permanent home may wish to consider these [naturalisation](#) criteria when planning their long-term immigration pathway, particularly following the grant of settlement.

27. UK Health and Care Worker Visa FAQs

Who is eligible to apply for a Health and Care Worker Visa?



What jobs qualify for a Health and Care Worker Visa?



Do I need to be registered with a UK professional body?



Can care workers bring dependents to the UK?



What is the minimum salary requirement for a Health and Care Worker Visa?



How long is the visa valid and can it be extended?



Is the Immigration Health Surcharge payable under this route?



How quickly is the Health and Care Worker Visa processed?



Can I switch to a Health and Care Worker Visa from another UK visa?



Does the Health and Care Worker Visa lead to settlement?



28. How Our Immigration Barristers Can Help



Applying for a Health and Care Worker Visa involves detailed legal and procedural requirements, including specific rules on eligible jobs, salary thresholds, professional registration, and sponsor compliance. At Richmond Chambers, our immigration barristers provide expert legal support to both health and care professionals and sponsoring employers at every stage of the process.

Advice for Health and Care Worker Visa Applicants

We work closely with healthcare professionals, care workers and allied health practitioners seeking to live and work in the UK under the Health and Care Worker route. Our barristers can:

- Assess your eligibility based on the relevant Standard Occupational Classification (SOC) code, salary requirements, and English language proficiency;
- Advise on registration with the appropriate UK regulatory body (e.g. NMC, GMC, HCPC) and the implications for sponsorship and visa approval;
- Prepare and submit Health and Care Worker Visa applications with carefully structured supporting documents to minimise risk of refusal;
- Advise on switching from other immigration categories (including the Student and Graduate routes) and on bringing dependants where permitted;
- Support applications for visa extensions and Indefinite Leave to Remain (settlement), including continuous residence and salary compliance;
- Provide guidance on progressing to British citizenship following the grant of settlement.

Our approach is thorough, tailored, and focused on securing a smooth and successful outcome.

Health and Care Worker Sponsor Licence Support

We also assist UK health and social care sector employers with obtaining and maintaining sponsor licences for the recruitment of overseas workers. Our business immigration barristers provide strategic advice to:

- Prepare and submit sponsor licence applications for NHS bodies, care providers and other eligible organisations;
- Ensure compliance with sector-specific requirements, including CQC regulation for care homes in England sponsoring care workers and senior care workers;

- Advise on appropriate SOC codes and salary thresholds under Appendix Skilled Occupations and the Immigration Salary List;
- Support the assignment of Certificates of Sponsorship (CoS) and ensure proper record-keeping and reporting procedures are in place;
- Advise on meeting sponsor duties when changes occur, such as role changes, promotions or contract terminations.

Ongoing Compliance and Sponsor Risk Management

Maintaining a sponsor licence requires careful attention to Home Office compliance obligations. We help employers to:

- Understand and discharge sponsor duties, including reporting, record-keeping and monitoring responsibilities;
- Conduct internal compliance audits and prepare for Home Office inspections;
- Respond to sponsor licence suspensions, downgrades or revocations;
- Navigate changes to sponsored workers' circumstances, such as job role, working hours, or changes in immigration status.

Whether you are a healthcare professional seeking to start or continue your career in the UK, or an employer wishing to recruit skilled overseas workers, our immigration barristers provide expert, strategic, and practical advice throughout the Health and Care Worker Visa process.

29. Contact Richmond Chambers Immigration Barristers

At Richmond Chambers, we pride ourselves on being approachable, responsive and proactive in understanding and meeting the needs of our health and care sector clients. Our team of immigration barristers is highly experienced and committed to providing clear, strategic and dependable immigration advice, delivered with professionalism and care.

To speak with one of our immigration barristers about your Health and Care Worker Visa application, sponsor licence, or compliance obligations, please call us on +44 (0)20 3617 9173, email us at info@richmondchambers.com or complete our online enquiry form below.

WE CAN ALSO ASSIST WITH

[Switching into the Health and Care Worker Route](#)



Visa Extensions for Health and Care Workers



Change of Employment or Sponsor



Applications for Settlement as a Health and Care Worker



Applications for British Citizenship Following Settlement



Refusals, Administrative Reviews and Judicial Reviews



Sponsor Licence Applications for Health and Social Care Providers



Ongoing Sponsor Licence Compliance



WHAT CAN WE **HELP YOU WITH?**

To discuss your Health and Care Worker Visa application with one of our immigration barristers, contact our business immigration team on 0203 617 9173 or complete our enquiry form below.

open

LATEST ARTICLES EXPERT COMMENT AND INSIGHT FROM OUR IMMIGRATION TEAM

Applying for ILR as a Dependant of a Skilled Worker

By Annie Ee – Senior Legal Associate
31 Oct 2025

We answer some of the questions that are most frequently asked when applying for Indefinite Leave to Remain (ILR) as a dependent partner or a dependent child of a Skilled Worker.



Skilled Worker Dependent Visa Application Guide

By Georgina Griggs – Immigration Barrister
29 Oct 2025

The UK Skilled Worker route is for skilled professionals with a job offer in an eligible role from a licensed UK sponsor to work in the UK. Dependents of Skilled Workers can apply for permission to join or accompany the Skilled Worker.



UK Immigration Salary List 2025

By Georgina Griggs – Immigration Barrister
08 Oct 2025

On 4 December 2023, the Home Secretary announced several changes to the immigration system related to the Skilled Worker route. Amongst these changes, it was announced that, from April 2024, the Shortage Occupation...



More



to top



immigration barristers

Richmond Chambers LLP is a limited liability partnership registered in England and Wales and authorised and regulated by the Solicitors Regulation Authority (licence number: 597974). Immigration barrister members are also regulated by the Bar Standards Board.

CONNECT WITH US

NAVIGATION

[Home](#)[Personal Immigration](#)[Work & Business Immigration](#)[About Us](#)[Careers](#)[Testimonials](#)[Knowledge Centre](#)[Contact](#)

RICHMOND CHAMBERS LLP

LONDON OFFICE

Richmond Chambers LLP
Seven Henrietta Street
Covent Garden
London
WC2E 8PS

T / +44 0203 617 9173

E / info@richmondchambers.com

MONTREUX OFFICE

Avenue Des Alpes 80B
Montreux 1820
Switzerland

T / +41 21 588 07 70

E / info@richmondchambers.ch

ACCREDITATIONS



© copyright - [richmond chambers](#) immigration barristers / 2025

[Legal Notices](#) | [Privacy & Cookies](#) | [Accessibility](#) | [Sitemap](#) |

[Modern Slavery Statement](#)